UX RESEARCH CASE STUDY · 12 WEEKS

POP Usability Evaluation

Discovering usability issues with a social-networking app prior to

product launch IXDF course

CLIENT
POP(Local Startup)

MY ROLE
UX Researcher

DURATION
12 Weeks

RESEARCHER
Olalekan

TOOLS
Figma · Miro · Airtable · Zoom

[PIN] PROJECT SCOPE

Client Kickoff

ThePOP app facilitatesfriendships based on shared interests for university students. POP'slong-termgoal was to improve the mental health of university students by providing meaningful social connections.

Client	POP, a local startup
Timeframe	12 weeks
My Role	UX Researcher
Team	Mia Eltiste, Metinee Ding, Ayu Larasati, Janani Ravikumar
Methods	Usability Testing · Prototyping · Heuristic Evaluation · Competitive Analysis · SME Interview
Tools	Figma · Miro · Airtable · Zoom

[OBJ] Objectives

- Understand the pain points of students and their social network at college
- Assess the usability and user experience of the POP app
- Prioritise recommendations so POP can address users' deepest pain points

[NOTE] PROJECT NOTE

Atthetime of assessment, POP had a working Figma prototype for the heuristic evaluation. Shortly after, POP launched on TestFlight

Methodology

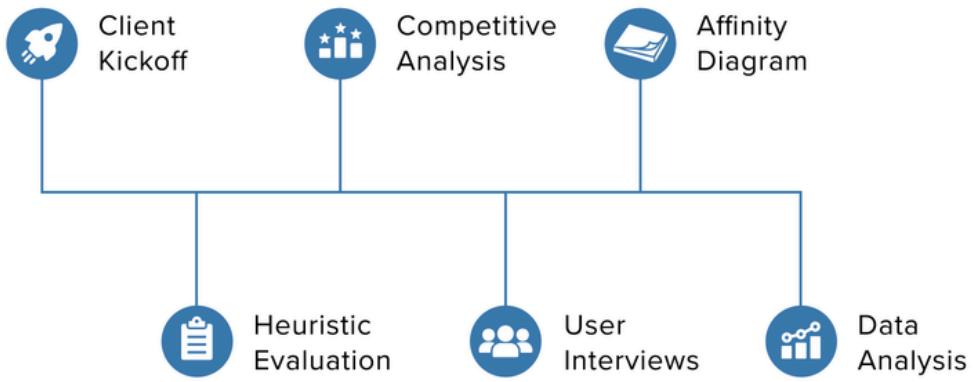
- Heuristic Evaluation
- Competitive Analysis
- User Interviews
- Affinity Diagram
- Data Analysis

5
Research Methods

4
Team Members

65+

12
Weeks



Research process diagram — outlining the 5-phase approach used across the 12-week study

Research Process Overview

[HEUR] PHASE 1

Heuristic Evaluation

> **[TIP] UX TIP**
> *A heuristic evaluation is a great way to grab low-hanging fruit and identify predictable usability issues. Use Nielsen's 10 Heuristics as a guide — they're "rules of thumb" that surface again and again in UI designs, but don't let them limit you.*

The project started with the startup's Founder speaking to the class. With a working Figma prototype already in place, the team began immediately with a Heuristic Evaluation to hand off early wins while the broader study progressed.

Sections Evaluated

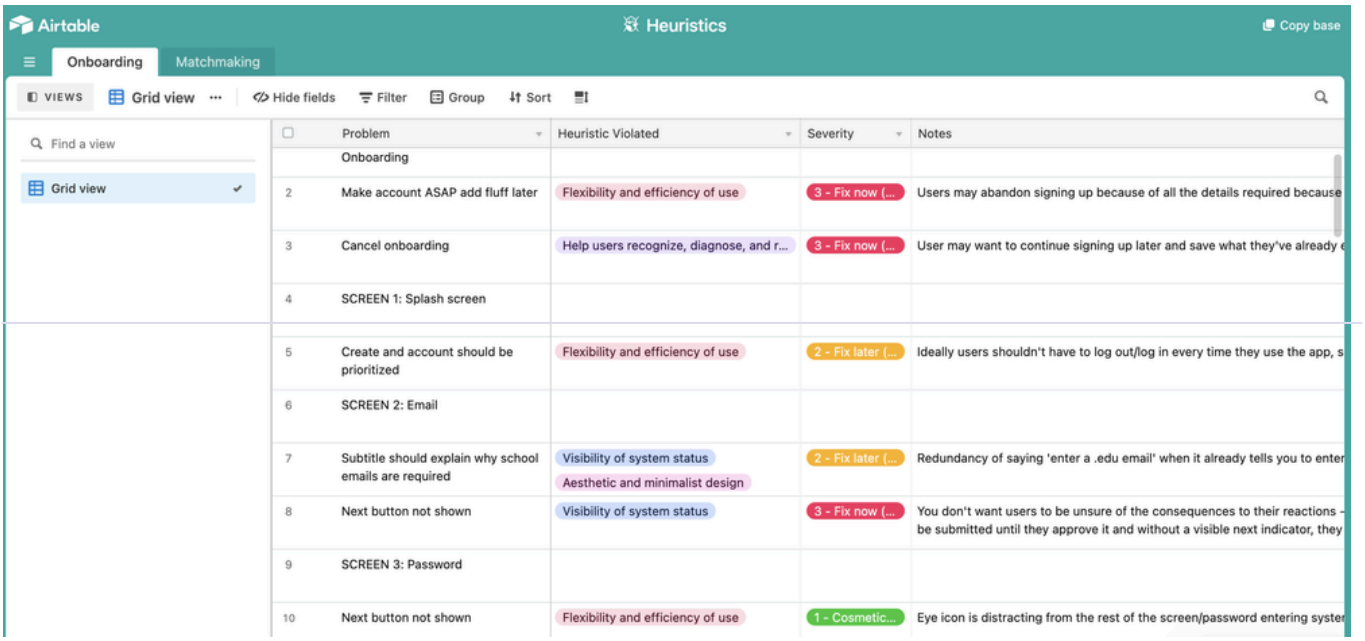
1. The **onboarding process** — every user goes through this once to create their account
2. The **matchmaking and chatting process** — users go through this repeatedly as they interact with the app

The team used Airtable to tag notes by the 10 heuristics violated and mark the level of severity for each issue found.

29
Visibility of System Status

18
Consistency & Standards

18
User Control & Freedom



Airtable Heuristic Tracker

Key Findings

1 · KeepUsersInformed

POP should provide feedback to help users know they're on the right track, especially around the most critical tasks — matching and messaging.

- Add a progress bar and confirmation feedback during onboarding
- Clear indicators prevent confusion and app abandonment

Heuristic: Visibility of System Status

2 · Give Users Control

POP should allow users to fix mistakes or make changes at any point during their experience.

Allow un-matching at any time

Let users edit avatars, codenames, and profile details after creation

Heuristic: User Control & Freedom

3 · BeConsistent

POP should follow industry conventions familiar to its target users, many of whom know apps like Tinder and Bumble.

Use similar information hierarchy on profiles

Only allow messaging after a successful match

Heuristic: Consistency & Standards

[COMP] PHASE 2

Competitive Analysis

The team compared POP against Bumble, Meetup, Friender, Nextdoor, and Meet My Dog — focusing on platonic connection apps and matchmaking conventions.

APP	PLATONIC	ANONYMOUS	EXCLUSIVE	STATUS
POP *	Yes	Yes	Uni only	Active
Bumble	Yes	No	Open	Active
BFF Friender	Yes	No	Open	Inactive
Nextdoor	Yes	No	N eighbour	Active
Meetup	Yes	No	Open	Active
Meet My Dog	Yes	No	Niche	Limited

Key Findings

1 Exclusive Membership

POPis the onlyplatform exclusive to university students. Both direct and indirect competitors used open community approaches. Nextdoor shows that exclusivity by geography drives strong engagement — POP could see similar results with its university focus.

2 Anonymous Profiles

Anonymity isPOP's biggest differentiator across all competitors — but it introduces novel risks. It increases cognitive load for remembering matches and raises questions about how anonymity affects user behaviour and offline safety.

3 Friender Tried It Already

Friender was theclosest directcompetitor, focused on platonic connections without anonymity. It is no longer active. With social networks, value is proportional to existing user base — new entrants face a steep climb.

[USERS] PHASE 3

User Interviews

> **[TIP] UX TIP**
> *User interviews are among the most powerful research methods. Even a small number of participants can surface critical insights — as long as you know how to ask the right questions and avoid confirmation bias.*

Methodology

- **Screener:**Diverse group — freshmen to seniors, in/out-of-state, international students, and transfers
- **Remote moderation:** Zoom + Figma prototype (project moved online from Jan 2020)

The Process

- Sixtasks chosen for the usability test
- Team of four — each covered four sessions (two moderating, two note-taking)
- Created an interview script, task-reference deck with Likert scales, and a codebook for note-takers

INTERVIEWS

Participant Data

Total Participants

8

Male 3

Female 5

Standing

Freshman 1	Sophomore 2
Junior 2	Senior 3

Name	Gender	Year	Residency	Transfer?
Chelsea	F	Sr	In	
Saaim	M	Sph	In	Transfer
Pramila	F	Sr	Out	Transfer
Lauren	F	Sph	Out	
Lindsey	F	Jr	Out	
Avinash	M	Sr	Int'l	
Matthew	M	Jr	In	Transfer
Kayla	F	Fr	In	

Remote Usability Test Setup

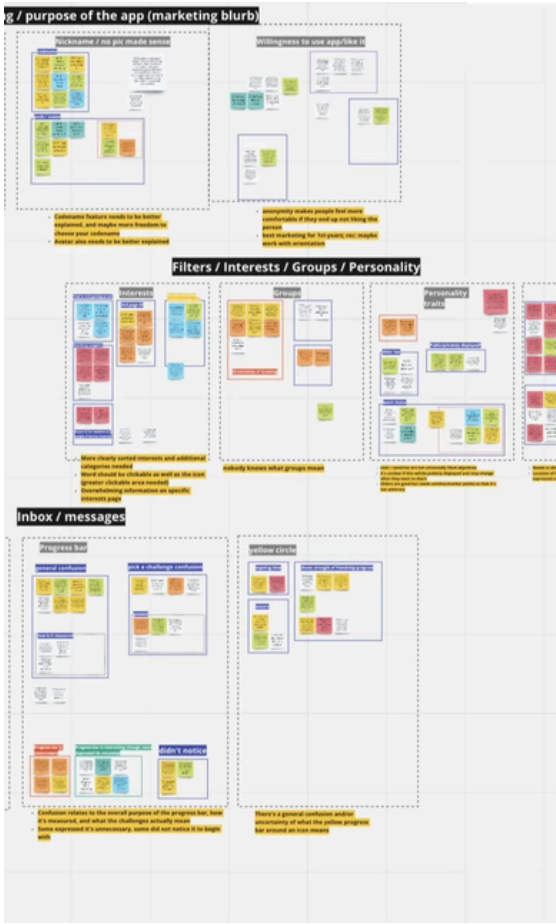
[AFFIN] PHASE 4

Affinity Diagram

> **[TIP] UX TIP**
> *Affinity diagrams help you find the "descriptive statistics" of qualitative*
> *data — surfacing themes without rigid coding.*

The Process

- Stickies grouped by task / screen with participant ID
- Within each task, grouped by impact: positive, negative, neutral
- Themes synthesised into insights, then into recommendations



Affinity Diagram — Miro Board

[DATA] PHASE 5

Data Analysis

Key Findings

- POP was a**fairly usable app** — similar to matchmaking apps its users already know
- Users struggled most with **novel features** that deviated from familiar conventions
- Usability issues were minor inconveniences — the real struggle was **understanding the app's purpose**

[REC] OUTPUT

Recommendations

1 ConductFurtherDesirability Research

- A perfectly usable app does no good if users don't want to use it — shift focus to desirability
- Focus on pain points to assess product-market fit
- Explore viable revenue streams; university partnership liability may be a barrier

2 Design for the Effects of Anonymity

- Allow users to create meaning and uniqueness in their profiles
- Lower the effort needed to make and keep connections
- Reduce cognitive load from anonymous profiles to keep users engaged

3 Follow Industry Standards

- Add confirmation screens to reduce confusion
- Reduce information overload
- Use conventional feature placement for learnability

4 Comprehensive Onboarding

- Clarify anonymity and privacy upfront
- Highlight differentiators to boost engagement and perceived value

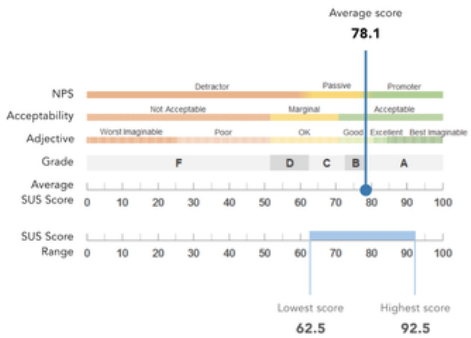
ANALYSIS

SUS Scores

The average SUS score for POP was **78.1**, based on 8 responses.

The scores ranged from **62.5** to **92.5**.

The industry average score is **68**.



[REFLECT] REFLECTION

Lessons Learned

POP was a fairly usable app — which made the recommendations feel nonessential. The real problems ran deeper than usability.

Industry Takeaway

Theproblems uncovered in userinterviewswere rooted inthe **desirability of the app** and failing to understand users' real pain points — not usability.

This project demonstrated the **limitations of evaluative research** when generative research has not been done first to validate product-market fit. A usable product that nobody wants is still a failed product.

Personal Takeaway

Coming from a startup background, the researcher recognised problems outside a traditional UX researcher's scope — such as appropriate revenue streams and partnership liabilities.

This required **balancing genuinely helpful insights** that weren't strictly UX-related while staying within professional boundaries.

Research Framework Used

- Heuristic Eval
- Competitive Analysis
- User Interviews
- Affinity Diagramming
- Usability Testing
- Data Synthesis

[INS] KEY INSIGHT

Thebiggest lesson: evaluative research can only tell you how well something works — not whether it should exist. Generative research must come first.

About the Researcher

Mia Eltiste is a UX Researcher with expertise in usability testing, qualitative research, and product strategy. This case study was completed as part of a university-level UX curriculum.

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VIEW FULL CASE STUDY

Full deck available at